friendship to the GFP, which is dominant in the Madgaon area. Election strategist Prashant Kishor had favoured the GFP merging with the TMC and making its chief, Vijai Sardesai, their chief ministerial candidate. Sardesai declined the offer and chose to go with the Congress.

The TMC's biggest achievement has been the alliance with MGP, which ruled Goa in the 1970s. The MGP's influence began to diminish with the rise of the BJP in the late 1990s. The party now has a sizeable presence in only seven of the 40 assembly constituencies. The alliance between Mamata's party and the Hindutvavadi MGP is seen as the biggest paradox of the Goa election. MGP leader Sudhin Dhavalikar is a patron of the Sanatan Sanstha; the outfit is the main accused in the 2009 Madgaon bomb blast and the murders of rationalists Narendra Dabholkar, Govind Pansare and M.M. Kalburgi (between 2013 and 2016).

The two parties have justified their pact. "The alliance is a wonderful blend of the Trinamool's fighting spirit and the MGP's long history in Goa. We believe this union will take Goa forward," said Moitra on December 7 last year. MGP chief Deepak Dhavalikar says the alliance will play a critical role in stopping the BJP. Dhavalikar has had a bitter experience with the BJP. In 2019, the party engineered a rift in the MGP by inducting two its three MLAs and later sacking Sudhin Dhavalikar from the BJP government led by Pramod Sawant.

Downhill for the Congress

The Congress has suffered the biggest losses in Goa in the past five years. In 2017, it had emerged as the single largest party with 17 seats. Mass defections and resignations have shrunk the party to a two-member presence in the state assembly. Worse still, both state president Faleiro and working president Alexio Reginaldo Lourenco joined the TMC.

The entry of two influential leaders, though, has lifted Congress spirits. Former minister Michael Lobo of the BJP made a return to the Congress on January 11. Prasad Gaonkar, the independent MLA from Sanguem, joined the party two days earlier. Lobo wields clout in the Calangute, Siolim, Mapusa and Saligao seats. While in the BJP, the MLA from Calangute had been demanding a ticket for his wife from Siolim and had threatened to back the Congress in the six constituencies of Bardez taluka. With Lobo's help, the Congress hopes to inflict damage on the BJP in at least four constituencies.

The Congress has announced candidates in 15 constituencies and convinced its ally, GFP, to settle for two seats—Fatorda and Mayem. GFP chief Sardesai and Lobo share a good equation and the Congress hopes to use their combined might to corner the BJP in its bastion of north Goa. Many in Goa, though, see the Congress-GFP alliance as a mismatch as Sardesai's party pursues a 'Goa for Goans' ideology. They, however, find common cause in fighting the BJP. "Our sole objective is to save Goa from the clutches of the BJP," says Girish Chodankar, state Congress president.

The Congress says the TMC grand alliance idea came late in the day. "The TMC should have approached us much earlier. Just days ago, they said the UPA was dead," says Congress co-in-charge of Goa, Dinesh Gundu Rao.

BJP faces rebellion

After 10 years in power, anti-incumbency is the BJP's biggest enemy. It's also desperately missing their stalwart, the late Manohar Parrikar. Parrikar had managed to keep the MGP and GFP in its fold till his death in March 2019. This time, CM Sawant is finding it difficult to fulfil everyone's political ambitions. After Lobo's exit, the BJP's biggest challenge will be to keep the party united in north Goa. Parrikar's son Utpal has warned that he will contest as an independent if the party denies him a ticket in Panaji, the constituency his father nurtured for over 30 years. The BJP has a plan to repeat Atanasio Monserrate there.

In a smart move, the BJP has managed to bring two young and influential MLAs, Jayesh Salgaonkar (Saligao) and Rohan Khaunte (Porvorim), into its fold to counter Lobo's influence. The BJP is banking on Vishwajeet Rane, Chandrakant Kavlekar and Ravi Naik, all former Congressmen, to garner votes in north and south Goa. Sawant says his target is to win at least 22 seats, just over the simple majority mark, for the BJP. "Our target was 22 in 2022 but now I feel we will win more than that and come to power with a full majority," he says. He feels the scattered opposition will help the BJP. "Their talk of forming a grand alliance is a sign of their nervousness. I have faith in the people of Goa."

The AAP and the new Goa Su-Raj Party are the other vote-eaters in the fray. They are likely to cut into the votes of the Congress and BJP. The AAP had contested in 2017 too but couldn't open its account. This time too, the party does not have a credible face at the top. Its state convenor, Rahul Mhambrey, is in the fray from Mapusa. The Goa Su-Raj Party, led by former AAP leader Manoj Parab, is playing the Goa for Goans line, especially in local jobs. He has emerged as a mass leader in certain pockets of north Goa, sending the BJP into a tizzy. If Parab can convert his mass appeal into votes, it could be disadvantage BJP. ■

SWINGING FORTUNES

